

Ten Simple Rules authorship

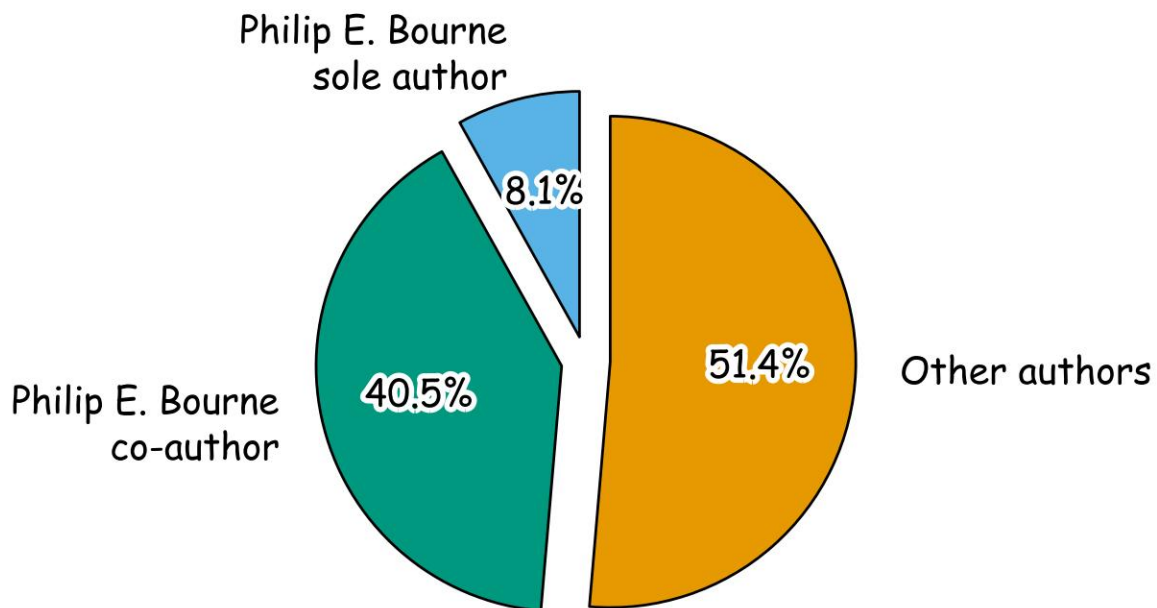


Figure 2. Your best chance of having a PLOS Ten Simple Rules article published is by being Philip E. Bourne.
doi:10.1371/journal.pcbi.1003858.g002

Rule 8: Reference

The ten rules format calls for a casual writing style, but that shouldn't prevent you from referencing. The need for citations will vary with the topic, however this is still a scientific journal, and this paper will form part of the scientific literature, indexed and found. There is plenty of scope for presenting your opinion, but do back up your facts. Wherever possible cite relevant online resources, including other Ten Simple Rules articles.

The caveat to this rule is that there can be such a thing as too many references. A great Ten Simple Rules article is easy to read and accessible to its audience. There is little point in having ten simple rules then overloading them with hundreds of references. Include only those that you have read and learnt from.

Resolve this conflict by considering how your article will be used. How many people will read it? Although references are important, Ten Simple Rules articles are viewed and downloaded more often than they are cited (Figure 3). In fact, by recent count, six of the top ten most viewed articles in *PLOS Computational Biology* were from the Ten Simple Rules collection. Clearly, the impact of your article will not be measured by citations.

By considering your audience (see Rule 7), you will get a sense for the number of

citations needed to effectively get your message across. Balance accessibility, brevity and authority, as these qualities that will determine how many people have a chance to follow your ten simple rules.

[PB: I love this graph (Figure 3). What does it say about impact? After all is this not what we are trying to measure? PLOS's efforts with article level metrics (ALMs) speak to the need to be more quantitative in how we measure the impact of a piece of scholarship. But since what we do most of the time is be qualitative—judging a piece of work by the impact factor of the whole journal—let me also be quantitative. Judging by the number of times someone I do not know comes up to me and says, “I know your work” and I respond, “really which research are you referring to?” Upon which they say, “I don’t know your research, I am talking about the Ten Simple Rules,” I would say the impact is high—at least relative to my research.]

Rule 9: Edit

Once you have the words on the page, your next step is to edit them. Present your rules in a logical order. Order and reorder them. Find the flow both between and within your rules.

Once you have taken care of the big picture, spend some time thinking about whether your paragraphs are cohesive and

well structured. This is not an essay, so the rules are a little more fluid, but you could still benefit from topic sentences and phrases that flow between paragraphs. If, like many academics, you find your sentences blow out beyond 30 words, you may like to use a tool such as Draft to keep them in check. These tools are great for picking up tortured sentence structures like passive voice and split infinitives.

One of the best ways to make your article more readable is to have others read it. Workshop and crowdsource your article. Your peers are your secret weapons. Many of them are your target audience, so you can do a test run and perhaps even get honest feedback.

Some literary theorists argue that as soon as you publish a piece of writing, it becomes the domain of the reader. The intent of the author pales in comparison to the interpretation of the audience. In this context, the reader is always right. So you may as well get the major criticisms and revisions out of the way early.

[PB: As I say somewhere in the collection, what you commit to the literature will be around long after you are gone—it is a large part of your professional legacy—get it right. Reviewers' comments often relate to the order and organization of the rules, so this rule is good advice for getting your contribution published and out there.]